This exhibition at the V&A, one of the few dealing with architecture held there in recent years, looks at Britain's unique contribution to international modernism in the mid-20th century, not at home, but in Ghana and India, where projects were selected, as the exhibition's principal curator Christopher Turner has written in the *V&A Magazine*, "that came to symbolise the utopian possibility of the transitional moment, a break with the colonial past articulated through art and architecture." This should be part of a wider examination of how European modernism responded to tropical climates, as there is no mention of countries such as Mexico, Brazil and Ethiopia, which did not have a mid-20th century disengagement from colonialism, nor of countries that did, such as Malaysia and, most significantly, Sri Lanka. But that would have required a far larger exhibition.

The thread that runs through the two case studies selected for this exhibition is the husband-and-wife team of Maxwell Fry and Jane Drew, who built up a profitable post-war practice in British West Africa (now divided between Ghana, Gambia, Nigeria and Sierra Leone) and worked from 1951 with Le Corbusier in Chandigarh. In Africa, they tended to specialise in large-scale public buildings, many of which were funded by the British government as part of the retreat from empire. This was a less generous action than might at first appear, as initially it was intended to stave off growing calls for independence, whilst post-independence, it ensured that British architects and contractors remained key to the development of the new nations. The tropical zone was treated as a homogeneous entity and did not address regional cultures and conditions, a common critique now levelled at European modernists of this period.

In Chandigarh, where Fry and Drew were responsible for new housing, there was some social engineering. 'Custom' was something to be eradicated from the designs. Climate



RIBA

THE TRIUMPHANT SUCCESS LAY IN THE TRAINING OF INDIAN ARCHITECTS, REALISING NEHRU'S HOPE THAT CHANDIGARH WOULD BE A LIVING ARCHITECTURE SCHOOL

was the design driver and despite the building of prototypes of the new housing that were lived in, criticised and improved, only two options would be presented. Ever-present was the conviction that if the inhabitants were shown the right models (i.e., modernist ones) they would prefer them. By and large, this worked and their housing remains popular today.

In India, this style was, of course, a total contrast to the final great construction project of the British Raj, New Delhi. In the exteriors and gardens of the Viceroy's House, now Rashtrapati Bhavan, one can argue a greater awareness of the complexities and history of Indian buildings than is present in Chandigarh, but then Jawaharlal Nehru wanted a symbol of his country's progress. Like Kwame Nkrumah in Ghana, he wanted to nurture a new generation of local architects to contract the architecture of a post-colonial nation. Chandigarh, as the new capital of the divided Punjab, was the showpiece. After something of a false



VICTORIA AND ALBERT MUSEUM, LONDON

MODERN TIMES Top, Jane Drew and Maxwell Fry; left, an installation at the Tropical Modernism exhibition; bottom, a scale model of Tower of Shadows, Chandigarh



THE MUSEUM OF MODERN ART, NEW YORK, SCALA, FLORENCE